The Marian Antiphon

Advent and Christmas, through Candlemas — *Alma Redemptoris Mater*.

Lent, through Holy Saturday — *Ave Regina caelorum*.

Eastertide, through Pentecost — *Regina caeli*.

Ordinary Time — *Salve Regina*.

The Salve Regina

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Hail, holy Queen, Mother of mercy,
our life, our sweetness, and our hope.
To thee do we cry, poor banished children of Eve.
To thee do we send up our sighs,
mourning and weeping in this valley of tears.
Turn then, most gracious advocate,
thine eyes of mercy toward us;
and after this our exile,
show unto us the blessed fruit of thy womb, Jesus.
O clement, O loving, O sweet Virgin Mary.

Pray for us, O holy Mother of God.
That we may be made worthy of the promises of Christ.
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A Simple Daily Plan for the Laity

The lay faithful are not bound to pray the Hours, but they are earnestly encouraged to:

- **Morning Prayer** after rising, before the day's work.
- **Evening Prayer** before or after the evening meal.
- **Night Prayer** before sleep.

One hour a day is a good start: the aim is to let the psalms and Scripture shape the whole day. Those who are bound to the Office by law follow the books of their own Church.

A Note on These Texts

Every prayer printed here belongs to the public worship of the Church, not to a private revelation. The canticles are the words of Sacred Scripture — Zechariah, Mary, and Simeon in Luke's first two chapters; the Te Deum is the Church's ancient hymn; the penitential formula and the blessing are her own liturgical texts; the Salve Regina is the medieval antiphon of Night Prayer. The psalms and readings that change day by day are taken from the approved breviary: this booklet is a companion for the Hours, not a substitute for it.

How to Pray the Liturgy of the Hours

The Hours, the Canticles, and the Fixed Prayers

The Liturgy of the Hours — the Divine Office — is the prayer of the whole Church, offered from morning to night. Its psalms, hymns, readings, antiphons, and collects change with the liturgical calendar and are found in the approved breviary. What does not change is printed here: the opening and closing verses, the three Gospel canticles, the Te Deum, the night examination of conscience, and the blessing.

Before You Begin

The Office needs a book: a one-volume edition of the Liturgy of the Hours, a monthly breviary booklet, or the texts published for each day. The psalms run on a four-week cycle, so that the whole Psalter is prayed about once a month; around the psalms the Church sets a Scripture reading, the writings of the Fathers on feasts, and a collect that gathers the day's prayer.

The first hour of the day may open with the **Invitatory** — Psalm 95, sung with an antiphon proper to the day — which calls the whole day to worship before the psalms of the hour begin.

The psalms are the spine of it. Everything else in the hour — hymn, reading, responsory, canticle, collect — is arranged around them, and they are prayed in the name of Christ and of the whole Church, not merely as private reading.

When the Hours are prayed alone, the responses are still said in full, and the blessing at Night Prayer is said by the one praying; in a church or a group the hours are usually sung, and the Gospel canticle is received standing. A candle, an icon, or the crucifix on the wall is enough to mark the place of prayer.

The Hours at a Glance

Office of Readings — any hour of the day, traditionally at night; on feasts it ends with the Te Deum.

Morning Prayer (Lauds) — at the beginning of the day; its Gospel canticle is the Benedictus.

Daytime Prayer (Terce, Sext, None) — mid-morning, midday, and mid-afternoon; simpler in form.

Evening Prayer (Vespers) — at the close of the working day; its Gospel canticle is the Magnificat.

Night Prayer (Compline) — before sleep; its Gospel canticle is the Nunc Dimittis.

The Shape of Each Hour

1. **Opening verse** — *God, come to my assistance.*

Night Prayer: The Examination of Conscience

Before the psalmody, a brief examination of conscience is made in silence, or with the penitential formula:

```
I confess to almighty God
and to you, my brothers and sisters,
that I have greatly sinned,
in my thoughts and in my words,
in what I have done and in what I have failed to do,
through my fault, through my fault,
through my most grievous fault;
therefore I ask blessed Mary ever-Virgin,
all the Angels and Saints,
and you, my brothers and sisters,
to pray for me to the Lord our God.
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It is an act of repentance, not the Sacrament of Penance, and it does not replace confession. At Night Prayer the examination is short: a moment of silence before God is enough, and then the psalms of the hour are prayed.

Night Prayer: The Nunc Dimittis

The Canticle of Simeon (Luke 2:29–32):

```
Lord, now you let your servant go in peace;
your word has been fulfilled:

my own eyes have seen the salvation
which you prepared in the sight of every people:

a light to reveal you to the nations
and the glory of your people Israel.

Glory to the Father, and to the Son,
and to the Holy Spirit:
as it was in the beginning, is now,
and will be for ever. Amen.
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Night Prayer: The Blessing

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May the all-powerful Lord
grant us a restful night
and a peaceful death.
Amen.
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Glory to the Father, and to the Son,
and to the Holy Spirit:
as it was in the beginning, is now,
and will be for ever. Amen.
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Evening Prayer: The Magnificat

The Canticle of Mary (Luke 1:46–55), said at the end of Evening Prayer:

```
My soul proclaims the greatness of the Lord;
my spirit rejoices in God my Savior,
for he has looked with favor on his lowly servant.

From this day all generations will call me blessed:
the Almighty has done great things for me,
and holy is his Name.

He has mercy on those who fear him
in every generation.

He has shown the strength of his arm,
he has scattered the proud in their conceit.

He has cast down the mighty from their thrones,
and has lifted up the lowly.

He has filled the hungry with good things,
and the rich he has sent away empty.

He has come to the help of his servant Israel
for he has remembered his promise of mercy,

the promise he made to our fathers,
to Abraham and his children for ever.

Glory to the Father, and to the Son,
and to the Holy Spirit:
as it was in the beginning, is now,
and will be for ever. Amen.
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The Magnificat is the Church's evening song, sung at Evening Prayer every day of the year; the hour that closes the day's work closes with the canticle of the Mother of God, which takes its name from its first word.

2. **Hymn** appointed for the hour or the season.
3. **Psalmody** — psalms or portions of psalms, each with its antiphon.
4. **Scripture reading** — longer at the Office of Readings, brief at the other hours.
5. **Responsory.**
6. **Gospel canticle** at Morning, Evening, and Night Prayer.
7. **Intercessions** at Morning and Evening Prayer.
8. **The Lord's Prayer** at Morning and Evening Prayer.
9. **Concluding prayer** (collect).
10. **Blessing and dismissal.**

Daytime Prayer is shorter: opening verse, hymn, three psalms, short reading, responsory, collect, dismissal.

The Opening

Said at the beginning of every hour except Night Prayer:

```
God, come to my assistance.
Lord, make haste to help me.

Glory to the Father, and to the Son,
and to the Holy Spirit:
as it was in the beginning, is now,
and will be for ever. Amen.

Alleluia.
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The **Alleluia** is omitted during Lent.

The Lord's Prayer

Said after the intercessions at Morning and Evening Prayer:

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Our Father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy name;
thy kingdom come;
thy will be done
on earth as it is in heaven.

Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our trespasses,
as we forgive those who trespass against us;
and lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil. Amen.
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The Dismissal

At the close of Morning, Daytime, and Evening Prayer:

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Let us praise the Lord.
Thanks be to God.
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The Te Deum

Sung or recited at the end of the Office of Readings on Sundays, solemnities, and feasts, and omitted during Lent. This is the approved English translation:

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You are God: we praise you;
You are the Lord: we acclaim you;
You are the eternal Father:
All creation worships you.

To you all angels, all the powers of heaven,
Cherubim and Seraphim, sing in endless praise:
Holy, holy, holy, Lord, God of power and might,
heaven and earth are full of your glory.

The glorious company of apostles praise you.
The noble fellowship of prophets praise you.
The white-robed army of martyrs praise you.

Throughout the world the holy Church acclaims you:
Father, of majesty unbounded,
your true and only Son, worthy of all worship,
and the Holy Spirit, advocate and guide.

You, Christ, are the King of glory,
the eternal Son of the Father.
When you became man to set us free
you did not spurn the Virgin's womb.

You overcame the sting of death,
and opened the kingdom of heaven to all believers.
You are seated at God's right hand in glory.
We believe that you will come, and be our judge.

Come then, Lord, and help your people,
bought with the price of your own blood,
and bring us with your saints
to glory everlasting.

Save your people, Lord, and bless your inheritance.
Govern and uphold them now and always.
Day by day we bless you.
We praise your name for ever.

Keep us today, Lord, from all sin.
Have mercy on us, Lord, have mercy.
Lord, show us your love and mercy;
for we put our trust in you.

In you, Lord, is our hope:
and we shall never hope in vain.
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Morning Prayer: The Benedictus

The Canticle of Zechariah (Luke 1:68–79), said at the end of Morning Prayer:

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Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel;
he has come to his people and set them free.

He has raised up for us a mighty savior,
born of the house of his servant David.

Through his holy prophets he promised of old
that he would save us from our enemies,
from the hands of all who hate us.

He promised to show mercy to our fathers
and to remember his holy covenant.

This was the oath he swore to our father Abraham:
to set us free from the hands of our enemies,
free to worship him without fear,
holy and righteous in his sight
all the days of our life.

You, my child, shall be called the Prophet of God,
the Most High.
You will go before the Lord
to prepare his ways,

to give his people knowledge of salvation
by the forgiveness of their sins.

In the tender compassion of our God
the dawn from on high shall break upon us,
to shine on those who dwell in darkness
and the shadow of death,
and to guide our feet into the way of peace.
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